Art outside the museum - *"Untitled" (Billboard of an Empty Bed)* (1991), Torres

Projects 34 was an exhibition sponsored by the Metropolitan Museum of Modern Art in New York, beginning on May 16, 1992, till June 30, 1992, presenting the work of the Cuban American artist Félix González-Torres, on view in the museum and in multiple sites throughout New York city. This work explored the boundaries between private experience and public realty, and the collapse of conventional distinction between the two, a reality more and more relevant as the time passes[1].

Félix González-Torres was born in Guáimaro, Cuba, in 1957. After leaving the country in 1971 and living both in Spain and Puerto Rico as a refugee, he moved to New York in 1979, where he attended the Whitney Museum of American Art Independent Study Program and received his in M.F.A. from the International Center for Photography[2]. Over the course of his career, he received several grants and fellowships, like the Gordon Matta-Clark Foundation (1991), the Lannan Foundation in conjunction with INTAR Gallery, New York (1990), and the National Endowment for the Arts. He worked as an adjunct art instructor at New York University until 1989, and he was a member of *Group Material*, together with Barbara Kruger, Jenny Holzer, Julie Ault, Louise Lawler, and Hans Haacke. The group was an art collaborative for conceptual artists dedicated to cultural activism[3].

A pivotal moment in his life occurred in 1983, when Torres meet for the first time Ross Laycock, in a gay bar on St. Mark's Place in New York's East Village. The two remained together for five years, ending tragically with Laycock's death from AIDS-related complications in 1991. This loss profoundly shaped González-Torres's artistic practice, much of his later work was dedicated to Laycock, reflecting themes of love, loss, and the struggle to endure grief, often serving as a tribute to Laycock[4].

In this context Torres conceived *"Untitled" (Billboard of an Empty Bed)* (1991), that later on will be in the *Projects 34* in collaboration with the MoMa, ifrom the grief he was experiencing and the desire to survive it. Felix itself, in an interview with Hans Ulrich Obrist, remember the pain and the need of an outlet, that he always found in his art:

"The billboards for MoMA came from a very specific personal impulse. I needed to see my bed; I needed distance first of all. Let me put it this way for you: I needed distance from my bed, and that bed became a site that was not only the place I sleep in, it was also the place of pain at night. That is the personal impulse."[5].

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[1] The Museum of Modern Art. (1992, May). Projects: Felix Gonzalez-Torres [Press release].
[2] Gonzalez-Torres, Felix and Hans-Ulrich Obrist. "Felix Gonzalez-Torres." Hans-Ulrich Obrist: Interviews. Vol. 1. Edited by Thomas Boutoux. Florence and Milan, Italy: Fondazione Pitti Immagine Discovery, 2003: 308 – 316.
[3] The Museum of Modern Art. (1992, May). Projects: Felix Gonzalez-Torres [Press release].
[4] Diamond, Shawn. "Felix Gonzalez-Torres, Ross Laycock & Carl George: An archive of love and loss at Visual AIDS." The Visual AIDS Blog. 31 July 2017.
[5] Gonzalez-Torres, Felix and Hans-Ulrich Obrist. "Felix Gonzalez-Torres." Hans-Ulrich Obrist: Interviews. Vol. 1. Edited by Thomas Boutoux. Florence and Milan, Italy: Fondazione Pitti Immagine Discovery, 2003: 308 – 316.

The billboard is just a black and white snapshot of his bed, still unmade, rumpled, with the impression of two body still present on the mattress, and most importantly, on the dented pillows. Something that was created to be simple, not aesthetic, but still became unforgettable. There is no text, only absence. The open interpretation of the photo is what makes her so important, with a different singular interpretation for every spectator, that could be loss, rest or erotic, from a private to a public debate, to just a picture of an unmade bed in an urban context. Each viewer brings his own perspective, transforming this piece in a shared, public experience[6]. A private image, full of personal pain but also a strong political statement, while not being entirely about homosexual love, AIDS and death. It's a complex piece, that investigate the lines between private and public, focusing on the public implications of a private individual's actions[7]. But who decide what is public and what is private when it really matters?

When talking about this piece in particular Torres always mention the recent political developments in America, the absence of privacy and the distinction between public and private spaces for the gay community and sexual acts. To be more precise he would refer to the case of *Bowers v. Hardwick* of '86, where the Supreme Court voted against the right of privacy for gay and lesbian couples. Because of this particular case their own bedrooms could be used against them in a court, becoming a public debate instead of safe place[8]. Even though Torres doesn't like defining his work as "political", or even about homosexual love, for fear of people missing the bigger picture, his art is part of him, it is not separated from his life, this work like many others from his, as still a political meaning and a hope for change[9].

Project 34 isn't his first billboard, that we can individuate in a earlier work, *Untitled (1989),* an artwork that consists of two lines of white tape that runs horizontally across the base of the rectangle, with a black background. It was installed above a busy intersection in the heart of Manhattan's, commemorating the 20th anniversary of the Stonewall Rebellion, the first civil uprising in response to police harassment and raids on gay bars. This rebellion is the start of the modern gay movement, and an important event in the contemporary history. For Torres this is a monument for the community, an architectural reference. The dates, names, and places visible are chosen both from a personal and public point of view[10] [11].

For *Projects 34* Anne Umland, at the time curatorial assistant at the MoMa, Department of Painting and Sculpture, proposed to Torres complete free rein. Her only idea was to help him

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[6] Chavoya, C. Ondine and Anne Umland. "Private Space on the Public Street: Felix Gonzalez-Torres's Bed Billboards." MoMA.org. 24 September, 2024.
[7] The Museum of Modern Art. (1992). *Projects 34: Felix Gonzalez-Torres: The Museum of Modern Art, New York, May 16–June 30, 1992*.
[8] Gonzalez-Torres, Felix and Hans-Ulrich Obrist. "Felix Gonzalez-Torres." Hans-Ulrich Obrist: Interviews. Vol. 1. Edited by Thomas Boutoux. Florence and Milan, Italy: Fondazione Pitti Immagine Discovery, 2003: 308 – 316.
[9] Umland, A. (1992, May). MoMA Projects 34 essay. The Museum of Modern Art.
[10] Public Art Fund. (1989, March–September). "Untitled" (Billboard), Sheridan Square, New York, NY [Press release].
[11] González-Torres, F. (1989). Artist's statement. New York City.

with his vision. They started talking firstly on the phone, because he didn't have a study, trying to find a project, an idea. One day, out of the blue, Torres called her about a new idea:

"I have a new idea for the Projects show. I'd like to put up [at that point it was 10 to 15] billboards around New York City. The image for the billboards should be a blowup of a photograph, a mundane image. I want it to look like anyone could have taken it. It should be a very private image, a private space, projected into the vast public arena of New York."

From this first idea of exposing something private in the public space, we can also see the notion of a fragmented exhibition, that can never be taken all in one. The artist expect the spectator to wander in the city to see the other pieces, because even though the image is the same, the surrounding and the final effect is different[12]. Not only we have the personal connotation of the snapshot, directly confronting the city and his social context, without the physical walls of a museum but all of our classic association with this common piece of furniture are broken. The location usually is one of the most private in the house, but the scale is completely different. All our assumption are posed in discussion, from the space where the artwork is posed, to the subject and his surrounding[13].

From Torres first visit to the museum he decided to do something different from the classic installation. After seeing the room, at first he wanted to leave it empty, with only the booklets with the list of city points in which to see the actual billboards. After some back and forth with the curator, the installation changed a little bit. Instead of the first idea, just the empty room with the booklets, Torres put the same billboard inside the Metropolitan Museum of Modern Art, joking on the "monetary worth" for the museum and the importance of having something to see inside the room. But the most important thing in the room was not the billboard itself, but the booklets with the information on where to find the others 24, not 10/15 as previous mentioned, billboards in situ, giving visitors the key to unlock the whole piece[14]. After the audience enters the gallery, the artist tells them to go back and live the city, to discovers with new eyes places they always see, street that they could have easily passed on the same week without noticing[15]. Anne Umland recalls many conversations about the exhibition inside the gallery, when they were still deciding what to actually have inside the space. She wanted to have something "attention grabbing" inside, to get people attention. She also remembers many conversation with the billboard company, Seaboard, for the installation of the pieces, and the fact that Felix told him to not treat the billboard as art, to not pay attention to the idea of perfection, but to work normally. The people putting up the billboard wanted to take extra time and extra precaution, since for them it was something artistic. But for Torres it wasn't. For him they were normal billboards, nothing different from what we see every day, with various

[12] Chavoya, C. Ondine and Anne Umland. "Private Space on the Public Street: Felix Gonzalez-Torres's Bed Billboards." MoMA.org. 24 September, 2024.
[13] The Museum of Modern Art. (1992). Projects 34: Felix Gonzalez-Torres: The Museum of Modern Art, New York, May 16–June 30, 1992.
[14] Gonzalez-Torres, Felix and Hans-Ulrich Obrist. "Felix Gonzalez-Torres." Hans-Ulrich Obrist: Interviews. Vol. 1. Edited by Thomas Boutoux. Florence and Milan, Italy: Fondazione Pitti Immagine Discovery, 2003: 308 – 316.
[15] Umland, A. (1992, May). *MoMA Projects 34 essay*. The Museum of Modern Art.

different ads. An important aspect of all this project was the location of the actual billboards. Even from the first, initial moment, they were supposed to be all across the city, in all the five boroughs, not only in the artistic Soho, where one might aspect to stumble across art. At the end, they were in four different boroughs: Queens, Manhattan, the Bronx, and Brooklyn, balancing what the artist wanted and the actual budget of the MoMa [16].

If in previous works Torres has taken elements normally seen as public, like pieces of newspaper, and isolated them, here we have the opposite process. His bed is the center of the contemporary, and varied, urban landscape, surrounded by the visual noise of the city (other billboards with colorful advertisements, traffic, different styles of buildings...)[17]. Even though they all showed the same image, the surrounding was an important piece of the puzzle to see the full effect intended for the artwork. In the brochure Umland writes: “Given the vitality of these places, it becomes almost impossible to keep our eyes on the photograph and that is the artist's intention. Yet at the same time as city and image vie for our attention, the urban landscape serves as a colorful foil against which the photograph's absolute reticence and interiority are starkly revealed.”[18] For the artist having the billboard shattered around the city was fundamental for the piece, as he explained “taking a little bit of information and displaying this information in absolutely ironic and illogical meetings", seeing a private image in the public space was a fundamental “illogical meeting” necessary. We don’t see the classic white wall of a museum, but a living city, full of colors and textures, against a black and white photo, that can only be seen as a whole with a good distance from the spectator, allowing to take everything in[19]. Since there weren’t any indication on the actual billboard, not even a word printed to give an indication, the full significance is left to the public. Everyone could see something different on the photo if they wanted to find it a significance, either love, emptiness, even an advertisement for sheets, whatever their mind prefers. This was what Torres intended for the piece, to leave the meaning free, because every reading works, even trough for him it was about being accepted[20].

For the curator the idea of not having a text inside the artwork was in relation to the theme of absence, not having something where you most expect it, going against the norm. Using a billboard without text goes against everything we usually see, instead here we have more of a reference to interiority, at giving attention even to the surrounding, urban, space. Torres invites the public to look around, to feel the community, to think about the social context. He loved

[16] Chavoya, C. Ondine and Anne Umland. “Private Space on the Public Street: Felix Gonzalez-Torres’s Bed Billboards.” MoMA.org. 24 September, 2024.
[17] Umland, A. (1992, May). *MoMA Projects 34 essay*. The Museum of Modern Art.
[18] The Museum of Modern Art. (1992, May). Projects: Felix Gonzalez-Torres [Press release].
[19] The Museum of Modern Art. (1992). Projects 34: Felix Gonzalez-Torres: The Museum of Modern Art, New York, May 16–June 30, 1992.
[20] Gonzalez-Torres, Felix and Hans-Ulrich Obrist. "Felix Gonzalez-Torres." Hans-Ulrich Obrist: Interviews. Vol. 1. Edited by Thomas Boutoux. Florence and Milan, Italy: Fondazione Pitti Immagine Discovery, 2003: 308 – 316.

the idea of his art inside a moment of transition, a glimpse of art inside an otherwise mundane commute, transforming a normal moment into something special [21].

The billboard also extended the duration of Torres project with the MoMa. The exhibition inside the museum was up in May and June of 1992, but some billboards were still up around the city in September, nonchalant about the fact that the exhibition was closed, indicating that *Projects 34* (Felix and MoMa project) was more than what is considered usual for a museum exhibition, creating a life outside those walls[22]. With the medium of photography we can also have the possibility of replication of the installation, bringing the project back to life under a different light[23].

In this way, *Projects 34* becomes more than an exhibition. It was an evolving, dispersed, public experience that invited viewers not only to observe but to move, reflect, and engage with the city itself.

[21] Chavoya, C. Ondine and Anne Umland. "Private Space on the Public Street: Felix Gonzalez-Torres's Bed Billboards." MoMA.org. 24 September, 2024.
[22] Chavoya, C. Ondine and Anne Umland. "Private Space on the Public Street: Felix Gonzalez-Torres's Bed Billboards." MoMA.org. 24 September, 2024.
[23] Conaty, K. (2012, April 4). Print/Out: Felix Gonzalez-Torres. The Museum of Modern Art.

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